

“stragglers,” troops deserted in the thousands. Hopes that Marylanders would flock to fill the ranks quickly evaporated. Those who wanted to fight for the Confederate cause had already gone South earlier in the war. Except by enslavers, the invading army was not welcomed as liberators. Most civilians barred their doors against them. The locals observed the ragged condition of the army with shock and awe. Describing the “gaunt starvation” evident in their faces, one Maryland woman, Mary Mitchell, wrote: “That they could march or fight at all seemed incredible.” Initially Lee had hoped Maryland’s fertile land would provide food and fodder. The reality was that his troops ate green corn and suffered in consequence.

DEFEAT IN DETAIL If a general has divided his army, in an adverse situation it can open up the possibility for his enemy to attack and crush each part separately or defeat it “in detail.”

Union stand

Lee had assumed that garrisons threatened by his advance into Maryland would be withdrawn to avoid capture. But the Union army at Harpers Ferry was ordered by the commander-in-chief, General Henry Halleck, to hold its position, despite McClellan’s protests. On September 9, General Stonewall Jackson marched the bulk of the Confederate army back across the river to seize Harpers Ferry. General James Longstreet was sent to Boonsboro to defend Jackson against a possible Union assault through the passes across South Mountain. But he was diverted to Hagerstown after a false report of a Union column marching toward him. Defense of the passes was left primarily to a division under General D. H. Hill, aided by General Jeb Stuart’s cavalry. By dividing his army, Lee exposed himself to “defeat in detail,” but again he gambled on McClellan’s inertia. With his forces scattered, Lee was to find he had miscalculated the state of the Union army.

The merger of the Army of Virginia into McClellan’s Army of the Potomac after Second Bull Run resulted in a remarkable revival of morale among Union forces. Soldiers greeted McClellan as a savior. Ordered by President Lincoln “to destroy the rebel army,” McClellan